HUMINT is the more promising discipline in terms of its potential to delve deep into the enemy's true intentions. This point deserves to be emphasized especially given today's reality, in which there is an almost religious worship of technology and a tendency to devote the lion's share of the intelligence budget to it.

A long-standing tradition in the intelligence world is the exchange of information and assessments between friendly intelligence agencies. Such exchanges will always be made between allied countries, but there is not necessarily always total symmetry between the two states' political interests and the interests of these countries' intelligence agencies.

The deeper and more intimate the cooperation, the more likely it is to result in joint operations. However, it is rare for one intelligence agency to share with another, friendly as the two may be, its top secrets—unless there is a "quid pro quo," in which the giving party receives a suitable reward in return. There is also an (unofficial, of course) intelligence "stock exchange," with buyers and sellers, and as in any stock exchange, the buyers try to buy cheap and sellers try to get top dollar. Typically, this "stock exchange" operates on the basis of a single seller versus a single buyer, but sometimes there is an "intelligence deal" involving more than two sides.

An ironclad rule of the global intelligence stock exchange is the "third-party principle," which states that the party that has acquired intelligence may not sell the "merchandise" that he has bought to a third party unless he has received the consent of the seller. It is difficult to ensure that this rule is always observed, but if and when those who breach it are exposed—and this does sometimes happen—their reputation is damaged, and the stock exchange members either refrain from selling them information or demand exorbitant prices for the information they need.

Intelligence stock exchange members should be very sensitive to the possibility that other members may try to sell them inaccurate information aimed at leading them to draw erroneous conclusions that serve the seller's goals—in other words, fraud. This has happened before and will happen in the future; information from sources controlled by foreign intelligence services must be treated with extreme caution.

The concept of information sharing is very general and broad. It can be examined through many different prisms:

1. The security prism of the need-to-know principle